

Reflections on the contradictory predicament of the school uniform skirt as an educational tool in the sociocultural settings of Korea

Introduction

South Korea is ranked sixth globally in terms of cultural effect in 2021 (Adams, 2022), and its flourishing entertainment industry garners considerable attention in its social milieu. The characteristics of Korean society, in conjunction with the ambiguous identity-seeking predicament of women, illustrate the circular relationship between society and education. Kim (2011) claims in K-pop research that Korean females' sexuality is currently constructed on the basis of their contradicting images. Even if Western feminism inspires them, Korean girls are not able to escape the clutches of the traditional, male-centered view of what it means to be a woman (Sedgwick, 1990). School uniforms act as a disciplinary tool regulating children's bodily hygiene, dictating how the body should be displayed at school (Kannan, 2022). Considering the extent to which this norm is a result of social construction, Hobsbawm (1992) labels it an "invented tradition." In other words, the original intent of school uniforms as a tool for education might be misinterpreted and distorted within a social culture, thus deviating from their true purpose. In this sense, the connotations carried by the school uniform skirt in terms of both habitus and identity formation remain malleable as a substantive medium (Allan, 2009), despite the fact that it is stylized and ingrained in the image of the girl (Ringrose & Rawlings, 2015). On the premise that the ideal of what constitutes beauty for women is sociohistorical, emerging, and evolving through the shared performance of social practises (Entwistle, 2002), it cannot be denied that the school uniform

skirt has the potential to positively influence both individuals and society. Similar to the recurring causes and consequences in the chicken-and-egg conundrum, this reveals the dynamic relationship between society and education. Due to the impossibility of simply adopting overseas practises as habitus and the incompatibility of the social environment and educational system under the heavily homogenised nature of Korean culture, this essay argues that long-term education should be required to alter the social habitus and improve the effectiveness of school uniforms.

The contradiction between western and indigenous cultures

Marshall (2022) is a journalist who claims that South Korea's national culture was originally established through cultural appropriation. As his article's title, "South Korea is stealing from the West," suggests, K-dramas and K-pop have become cultural hybrids by adopting Western trends and practises (Sung, 2014; Sun et al., 2022). Clothing is the most straightforward way of expressing oneself. Various items can be utilised to distinguish honorific categories and facilitate calibration, as is customary in many public school uniform codes (Wilkinson, 1964). For instance, the blazer's stripes, the shirt's various colors, and the brooch This practise may have evolved into what Bourdieu (1977) terms a "dynamic habitus" in the west. Habitus, in Bourdieu's definition, is a habitual behavior. This set of enduring and acquired behaviours is in fact a result of social deposition, which enables actors to act in specific ways on a whim and without much conscious thought (Bourdieu, 1987, 1990; Navarro, 2006). The world has been shaped by a fluid and constantly recast set of dispositions based on the time-honored history and social transformations of the West (Frank & Bourdieu, 1980). The rise in

popularity of the short skirt in the West can be traced back to the emergence of concepts such as feminism and assertive female figures, as well as the occurrence of a variety of stiff resistance associated with them. This is the reason why young people in the West have the propensity to express their identity, values, and inventiveness through clothing, such as skirts.

When the Sookmyung Women's School brought the modern Western school skirt to Korea for the first time in 1907 (Park, 2013), it had a positive effect, whether it was to meet international standards or to change the uniform look. Regardless of whether the popularity of the short skirt is seen as a consequence or a process of struggle, it is evident that the significance of the short skirt in Korea, as long as women are momentarily unable to escape the grip of patriarchal values, is unidimensional (Campbell, 2015). Instead of the culture itself—in this example, the feminist movement—young people are imitating the intriguing exterior of western society. Indeed, it is impossible for Koreans to bypass the process of intellectual enlightenment and merely draw on their achievements. The embedded cultures would impede the arrival of alien civilizations. The Confucian cultural concept evoked in Korea views the female body as the state's womb, which needs to be governed (Seoul Street Fashion Week, 2016). By objectifying women, they are logically obligated to perform domestic chores and participate in physical reproduction. Historically, the exploitation of female labour has benefited the Korean economy, for instance, by significantly contributing to industrialization during colonialism (1910–1945) and the economic boom from 1961–1996 (Fedorenko, 2014). The ensuing issue was that career opportunities for Korean women had previously been limited and inexpensive. According to Appiah (2018), education, which contributes to the formation of habitus, along with status in the production system, which reflects power relationships and social position, collectively determine life chances. The result of this vicious circle is that even in the face of legislative restrictions, consumer culture and the sex industry still identify young girls' sexuality as a "sexual commodity" (Kim, 2003).

When western habitus was introduced as a unilateral habit in Korea, where internationalisation became the attribution of over-sexualized behavior, it diverged from its original meaning (Sun et al., 2022). However, this seems to be a valid phenomenon, since the "new gender regime" defines girls as the intersection of characteristics that were formerly considered antithetical to each other (McRobbie, 2009).

Furthermore, Korean feminists have discovered that using femininity and sex appeal to toy with patriarchy is becoming increasingly popular as girls' sexuality becomes a negotiable asset (Kim, 2003; Tasker & Negra, 2007). As the heteronormative market today dominates Korea's aesthetic regime (Allan, 2009), females make use of their uniforms and the femininity they portray, such as by simply shortening their skirt lengths, to advance in society. Adults who are accustomed to traditional patriarchal gender norms continue to see women as meek, subservient, and inconspicuous (Kim, 2003; Lee, 2013). They apparently lack sufficient habitus to carry out Western practices; therefore, they begin to exclude and prohibit. The Gangwon Provincial Office of Education, for instance, spent over 820 million KRW in 2011 to instal fenders in front of approximately 5,500 tables to shield the legs of students wearing short skirts (Hankyung News, 2011). This might demonstrate that for many Koreans, wearing a short skirt is inextricably linked to a lack of self-esteem (Ringrose & Rawlings, 2015). Hence, although wearing short skirts or keeping them short is intended to resist the male gaze and the various societal exploitations and systemic restrictions on girls' bodies (Brooks, 2002), it is still considered slut-shaming in contemporary Korean society, along with unusual makeup and trendy hairstyles (Ringrose & Renold, 2012).

Meanwhile, it is impossible to deny that Koreans have a proclivity to recognise themselves in the perceptions of others (Kim, Do-hyoung 2011). Historiographically, Korean nationalism is centred on the ethnic and cultural homogeneity of all Koreans (Schmid, 1997). They are more inclined to identify themselves through their interactions with others than through their own accomplishments (Campbell, 2015). The standardisation of school uniforms serves as an additional catalyst for this convergence. Up until the 1980s, the legislation required that Korean schools wear almost identical uniforms. Regardless of the fact that the legislation is no longer in effect, Koreans nevertheless have the inclination to minimise their own prominence. The fact that both rule-makers and rule-bearers adhere to the traditional Confucian collectivist mindset explains why school uniforms remain highly popular.

The contradiction between institutional rule guidance and socio-cultural influence

This tension exists not only between foreign and indigenous cultures but also within Korea between educational regulations and societal norms. Also, it seems to have paved the way for a lot of extreme behavior, like the trend of getting skirts shorter and shorter or selling school uniform skirts to people with certain fetishes.

The fundamental reason for the emergence of the school uniform rule, from the school's perspective, is that it does have massive benefits. This includes, but is not limited to, promoting equitable competition, managing violent behavior, and allowing students to concentrate more on academic pursuits for a more motivated school climate (Stanley, 1996;

Anderson, 2002; Jones et al., 2020). It is critical to acknowledge the role of school uniforms in de-sexualizing children and preventing disruptive learning at its source, while also taking into account the contradictory situation that females, in particular, find themselves in. Without a doubt, schools are pivotal for advancing social civilization (Newman, 1977). The foundation of the school's conventional moral habitus, as defined by Bernstein et al. (1966), also includes decorum and modesty in opposition to sexuality and the flesh. Ostentation and erotic emphasis are seen as impure and irreligious expressions (Symes & Meadmore, 1996). Uniforms are also seen as a method to combat anxiety over nudity since they may be used to smooth out the body, deny body contours, neuter sexual identity, and counter libidinous attraction (Young, 1993). This explains why even in the West, like Wales, even if each school has varied skirt length requirements, there is at least a mention of the school uniform being appropriate (Wightwick, 2021). Furthermore, since they limit women's mobility, school uniforms could be an influential form of de-animation. To transcend beasts and creatures, individuals must develop free will and rationality through education (Symes & Meadmore, 1996). Girls who wear skirts appear more "feminine" because doing so requires them to act in a more "feminine" way, such as keeping their legs together or stepping more delicately, rather than because of the skirt's appearance per se (Park, 2013). According to Symes and Meadmore (1996), the wearing of school uniforms seems to negate any temptation that may impede study.

As Kannan (2022) observes in her survey, many girls have disregarded the presence of clothing that restricts their mobility, considering it a specific inconvenience that females must endure. Despite the fact that they are only expected to follow the rules in school, girls believe that short skirts are explicit, sexually-oriented, and carnal flaunting. Even after joining

society, they continue to follow these rules out of habitus. In this regard, it appears reasonable to presume that social norms match educational requirements, yet in practice, the social reality is too complex to generalize. K-pop studies claim that the bodies of girls in idol groups are sculpted and shown under the manipulation of entertainment companies and are objectified commercially. Their visual images are designed to be mature and seductive, whereas the youngsters exude youthful charm and allure in every gesture (Kim, 2011). This inconsistency does not only occur in K-pop groups. In fact, as part of the punishment and reward routines defined by Foucault et al. (1991), school uniforms have developed into both a code of behaviour for girls to follow throughout their lives and a mechanism for self-regulation. However, in Korean communities where females are still defined by male-centered norms and values (Kim, 2003), the fetishisation of the skirt gives it a more pornification or sexualization meaning (Walkerdine, 1990). According to Joshua et al. (2020), who discuss the dearth of female representation in police museums, the most prevalent evidence of the existence of female police officers in such a public space is mannequins dressed in women's uniforms. The only value they seem to have is merely as skirts; there are no writings that describe the tale or give it significance. This demonstrates a fascination with policewomen's uniforms (Joshua et al., 2020). Because socialisation and academics are inextricably linked, the sexualization reflected by the skirt is introduced not only in the public sphere but also on campus.

Korean society expects girls to be "attractive," and this self-monitoring of appearance as cultural capital is internalised by girls (Frost, 2005). Middle and high school students in Korea spend the majority of their time at school and increasingly wear their uniforms outside of school, making them an integral component of their wardrobes (Lee & Lim, 2010). It

seems absurd, but many young women go out dating while still dressed in their school uniforms. Owing to societal homogenization and a general lack of inventiveness (Kim, 2011), it is a typical practise for Korean girls to continue wearing short skirts but to make them shorter or roll them up in order to stick to society's expectations of being "attractive" (Park, 2013). The pervasive uniform culture has largely deprived students of individuality and the capacity to generate distinctive, unexpected, and meaningful thoughts (Boden, 2004; Park, 2013). Notwithstanding the fact that the new generations aspire to express their individuality through their appearance (Kim, 2003), they are held back by their paralysing worry that doing anything out of line will damage their reputation and cause them to be shunned by their peers and the consumer society at large.

Possible ways of coping in contradictory situations

As Miuccia Prada, the founder of the renowned luxury brand Prada, stated in an interview, "What you wear is how you present yourself to the world" (Galloni, 2007), appearance commonly functions as a vehicle of societal ideals conveying each individual's moral standing (Veblen, 1970). Clothing, in particular, is often used to change the way people look. However, Symes and Meadmore (1996) say that what happened in reverse is more important because people can give their clothes meaning. Here are two hypotheses that might contribute to the rectification of school uniforms as a beneficial tool. First off, by integrating other identities in order to counterbalance the injustice of female identity, one may make use of the identity messages that accompany school uniforms, such as being middle class. Second, through long-term education, feminist consciousness becomes an integrated set of beliefs,

called "habitus," so that new ways of doing things don't change because people aren't willing to accept them.

One prerequisite for achieving rectification is that girls recognise that the vulnerabilities they experience as women are not inherent in nature but rather produced by society (Beauvoir, 2015). To put it another way, choices made by an individual could influence their identity since it is not carved in stone (Appiah, 2018). According to Appiah's (2018) conceptual features of the identity formation process, identity is also crucial to the formation of habitus since it directs individuals to contemplate how they should behave under a label. The three basic qualities of labels are that they impose specific rules on individuals that they have to abide by, that they unconsciously mould the holder's feelings and behaviors, and that they influence how the holder is regarded. In conjunction with Kimberlé Crenshaw's (1991) notion of intersectionality, the meaning of identity for each holder is coloured by their other identities. If one were in the woman's shoes, the disempowerment of being a woman may be combined with an upper-class identification to create a new, likely authorized, identity. It appears that females may climb the social ladder and reverse their plight by utilising school uniforms or making use of their femininity in a society where hierarchy is rigid, social structure is entrenched, and patriarchy has not been eradicated. In addition, girls must recognise that it is always the stigmatisation of femininity, not femininity itself, that needs to be rejected. In public schools with a high percentage of students from middle-class households, the dress code is more stringent since the school uniform is seen as a tool to position oneself and acquire social capital (Bernstein, 1975). Among the many desiderata of middle-class women is the desire to dress appropriately at all times. They also employ this image to consolidate their social status through exclusionary and regulatory strategies

(Langland, 1995; Poovey, 2001) and to prove their "respectability" by portraying their female figure (Creese & Skeggs, 1998). For example, in Britain, the apparatus of being ladylike as appropriate attire allows girls to derive certain authority from their identity and differentiate themselves from the "vulgar" working-class masses (Allan, 2009).

On top of that, it cannot be disputed that long-term education may continually strive to improve the social atmosphere, even though the school uniform skirt as an educational tool appears to be slightly astray in contemporary Korean society under the impact of other dilemmas. When projected onto Korean society, the wearer is shown to be enslaved by the regulations by being subjugated by both the tangible script of school uniform norms and the intangible social convention. In this case, if we further restrict our focus to females, rather than a clash of viewpoints, the convergence of society makes it more perilous and taxing to implement change. In such a situation, people are compelled to pursue immutable and conforming worth. If we narrow our attention even more to women, besides the clash of viewpoints, the convergence of society will make it more perilous and taxing to implement change. With the assistance of long-term education, schools should continue to guide students to appreciate the profound message behind the school uniform skirt and experience the positive value of its proper use, thereby enabling the position of women in Korea to be genuinely elevated. To maximise long-term benefits, it is necessary to abandon imitating the superficial and instead devote more time and expense to penetrating or replicating the underlying ideas behind phenomena, including demonstrations or strikes.

Conclusion

This essay identifies how young Korean women are experimenting with the compromise between sticking to convention and expressing uniqueness by cutting their uniforms exceedingly short. In view of the heavy homogeneity of Korean society, adopting new practises becomes more challenging and more likely to have unintended consequences. Subsequently, two possible approaches are proposed to revive the benign implications of school uniforms. Being a Chinese girl who also resides in East Asia, it is inevitable for me to bring cultural bias to my study due to the marginally shared but impossibly equal interaction between the cultures of the East Asian nations. Besides, as globalisation and internet technology continue to advance, young Koreans have an expanding variety of options to obtain insight and cultural experience in Western societies. The International Trade Administration reports that, notwithstanding the burden of COVID-19, a total of 39,491 Korean students were enrolled in American institutions during the academic year 2020-2021. These students' firsthand exposure to Western culture not only benefits themselves but also gives Korea a unique and commendable window into the West's society. Girl's Crush as a fashion movement in Korea's burgeoning cultural sector captures the spirit of independent, strong women that permeates K-pop. It's a symbol of the millennial generation's rejection of conventional gender roles and pursuit of individual fulfillment (Kendall, 2002; Yang, 2020). Additionally, the success in cultural exports appears to herald that Korea has gradually advanced towards a new stage of acceptance and progress with the West as the movie *Parasite* won the 92nd Academy Awards for Best Picture and other awards, the TV series *Squid Game* became the most popular series of all time on the Western mainstream media Netflix (Keck, 2021), and the exhibition titled "Korean Wave" was placed in the V&A in London. Considering the recent changes in Korean society and the sensitivity of the culture,

this essay, although as up-to-date as is feasible, cannot ensure that its discussion is entirely pertinent to the current circumstances.

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